Ethical Lens: Utilitarianism

Utilitarianism

Let’s start with an AI example. Imagine a school district uses a predictive AI system to identify students at risk of dropping out.

The AI System

The AI analyzes attendance, behavior, and academic performance. With 85% accuracy it predicts which students will drop out. However, it mistakenly flags 15% of students who are not actually at risk.

Individual Costs

Some of the falsely flagged students receive unnecessary interventions from teachers, staff, and administrators. Because they are treated differently, the students feel stigmatized.

Collective Benefits

If the system prevents a significant number of actual dropouts, the long-term social benefit (improving lives and reducing public costs) of using the AI may outweigh individual harms.

The utilitarian ethical justification rests on this balance of net benefit—many gain, though a few may suffer undue consequences.

The Utilitarian Dilemma

CIA Scenario

Imagine the CIA learns of a plot to detonate a dirty bomb in a major American city. They capture a suspect believed to have information about the bomb's location. Is it permissible to torture the suspect to reveal the bomb's whereabouts?

The Ethical Question

Can the dignity (and perhaps rights) of one individual be violated to save many others? This dilemma encapsulates the core of utilitarian thinking: weighing individual rights against the greater good.

Core Principles of Utilitarianism

Greatest Good for the Greatest Number

Utilitarianism aims to maximize overall well-being and minimize suffering for all affected parties.

Consequence-Based Ethics

The morality of an action is judged solely by its outcomes.

Impartial Consideration

All individuals' interests should be weighed equally, without personal bias.

Historical Context

Jeremy Bentham (18th-19th century)

English legal reformer who sought an objective basis for determining just laws. Introduced the concept of “the greatest good for the greatest number.”

John Stuart Mill (19th century)

Expanded on Bentham’s ideas, focusing on the quality and intensity of pleasure and pain rather than just quantity. Proposed the idea of higher and lower levels of pleasure.

Modern Utilitarianism

Contemporary utilitarians often describe benefits and harms in terms of satisfying personal preferences or providing economic benefits.

Utilitarian Decision-Making Process

Identify Options

Determine all possible courses of action in a given situation.

Analyze Consequences

Predict all foreseeable benefits and harms for each option.

Evaluate Net Benefit

Choose the action that provides the greatest overall benefit after costs are considered.

Variations in Utilitarian Thought

Act Utilitarianism

Focuses on the consequences of individual actions. Asks: “What effect will my doing this act in this situation have on the general balance of good over evil?”

Rule Utilitarianism

Emphasizes following rules that generally produce the best consequences. Asks: “What effect would everyone’s doing this kind of action have on the general balance of good over evil?”

Lying Example

While an act utilitarian might justify someone lying in a particular situation, a rule utilitarian might see the consequences of everyone following a rule that permits lying in that situation to cause more harm than good.

Strengths of Utilitarianism

Impartiality

Encourages considering the interests of all affected parties equally.

Practicality

Offers a clear method for moral decision-making in complex situations.

Broad Applicability

Can be applied to personal decisions, business ethics, and public policy.

Challenges of Utilitarianism

Quantification Difficulty

Assigning values to intangible benefits and harms. How do we assign a value to life or compare the value of life to the value money provides?

Unpredictability of Consequences

Uncertainty in predicting all outcomes of actions.

Potential for Injustice

May justify unjust actions (like apartheid or slavery) if they benefit the majority.

Conflict with Rights

Some of the unjust actions that utilitarianism may permit are violations of people’s rights.